



UNITED ARAB EMIRATES

Capital city: Abu Dhabi
Area: 32,000 sq miles (82,880 sq km)
Population: 3,000,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 96%, other 4%
Government: Federation of monarchies
Currency: UAE dirham
Adult literacy rate: 77%
Life expectancy: 75 years
People per doctor: 556
Televisions: 294 per 1,000 people

OMAN

Capital city: Muscat
Area: 82,030 sq miles (212,460 sq km)
Population: 2,900,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 90%, other 10%
Government: Absolute monarchy
Currency: Omani rial
Adult literacy rate: 74%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 769
Televisions: 595 per 1,000 people

UNITED ARAB EMIRATES

THE UNITED ARAB EMIRATES (UAE) lies on the southern coast of the Persian Gulf. Three-quarters of this Islamic country is sandy desert, with a hot, dry climate all year round. Only a tiny proportion of the land is suitable for farming and most food has to be imported. Oil was discovered in 1958 and has turned the UAE into one of the world's most prosperous countries, with a high standard of living for most people. There are many huge oil refineries along the coast.



Abu Dhabi

TOURISM

The UAE has a growing tourist industry. Some 2.5 million people arrive each year, mainly from Europe and Japan. Most visit in winter when it is warm, but not too hot. Attractions include luxury hotels and duty-free shops, traditional markets, fine beaches, and trips into the desert.



Al Mamza Beach Park, Dubai

SEVEN STATES

The United Arab Emirates is a federation of seven small states, or emirates, each ruled by an emir, or sheik. The emirs have absolute power over their own states, but they also meet regularly to make decisions affecting the whole federation. Abu Dhabi is the largest of the emirates and its capital is also that of the UAE.

ISLAMIC FESTIVALS

The two most important festivals of the Islamic year are *Id al-Fitr* and *Id al-Adha*. *Id al-Fitr* literally means "the breaking of the fast." It celebrates the end of the holy month of Ramadan, during which Muslims must fast from dawn to dusk. *Id al-Adha* is the festival of sacrifice. Prayers are followed by the sacrifice of a sheep, cow, or camel.

A Muslim family celebrating *Id al-Fitr* (left)
 The feast consists of typical Middle Eastern foods, such as those shown on the right.



Dates



Apricots and dates are often eaten as appetizers.



Dried apricots



Lentils are used to make soups.



Zucchini is often eaten with a main meat dish.

OMAN

THE SULTANATE (KINGDOM) OF OMAN lies on the southeastern coast of the Arabian Peninsula. Much of the land is desert, dotted with oases, but parts of the coastline are more fertile. Here farmers grow dates, pomegranates, limes, tobacco, and wheat. People also raise goats, sheep, and cattle. Oil is Oman's main export.



Omani fishermen



FISHING

The Oman coastline is 1,056 miles (1,700 km) long, and fishing is a valuable source of income and food. Omani fishermen catch large amounts of sardines, tuna, anchovies, cod, and cuttlefish. They use traditional dugout canoes equipped with outboard motors for greater speed.

LOST CITY OF THE SANDS
 According to Arabian legend, a magnificent city called Ubar lies buried under the desolate sands of southern Oman.

Archeologists have excavated a watering hole and the remains of a city dating from about 3000 BC near the Yemen border. Some experts believe that this is the lost city of Ubar.

Find out more

DESERTS: 15, 132, 152
 ISLAM: 275
 OIL: 137, 152, 281
 OIL WEALTH: 137, 278